The effects of persistent itching can spill over into everyday life, affecting routine activities, work and personal/ social comfort. Pruritus, for instance, can ruin sleep, make it difficult to concentrate and leave people constantly conscious of how their skin looks. For 24-year-old Ahmedabad-based graphic designer Arohi Desai, it meant wearing full sleeves even when the weather did not permit. What had begun as an itchy rash on her forearms in no time spread into rough, darker patches. "It looked like my skin had been scraped and stained at the same time," says Desai. When people kept asking her what it was, she decided to cover her arms rather than attract unwanted attention.

WHAT CAUSES AN ITCH

Most often, an itch can be triggered by something as basic as the environment around us. Low humidity can cause dry skin and itching; heat and humidity can do the same with increased sweating, which allows moisture to accumulate, particularly in skin folds, a problem compounded by tight or poorly ventilated clothing that keeps sweat in contact with the skin longer. "Fabrics such as polyester can trap heat and sweat, while pollution can irritate already sensitive skin," says Dr Sarita Sanke, head of dermatology and cosmetology at Yashoda Medicity in Ghaziabad.

Airborne allergens such as pollen, dust mites and pet dander can also provoke inflammation, particularly in people with sensitive skin. Persistent inflammation may contribute to eczema, which appears as dry, red and intensely itchy patches. Some foods, such as nuts, eggs and shellfish, as well as certain medications, can trigger hives, which you may recognise as raised, swollen welts that can itch fiercely. Scabies, caused by tiny mites that burrow into the skin, often causes particularly intense itching at night.

However, one of the most common causes of itching is fungal infection. In a 2026 multicentre study published in the *International Journal of Research in Dermatology*, 95 per cent of 373 dermatologists identified itching as the predominant symptom of fungal infection. A separate 2026 multicentre Indian study, published in *Clinical, Cosmetic and Investigational Dermatology*, examined records of 6,169 patients and found fungal infections to be the most frequently diagnosed skin condition. These infections cause itching when fungi, including dermatophytes and yeasts, affect the skin. Athlete's foot, for instance, can cause itching, cracking and peeling between the toes. Jock itch affects the groin, while candidiasis can develop in warm, moist skin folds, including the armpits, beneath the breasts and around the groin, producing a red, itchy and burning rash.

The modern lifestyle, too, is presenting the skin with a growing range of potential irritants. Skincare and cosmetic products, frequent cleansing, fragrances, hair products and active ingredients all increase the chances of a



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